

WIF India Screenwriters Lab

Discovering Voices. Crafting Cinema. Driving Change.
Genre-based, Mentored, Pan-India Feature Film Development Lab

OVERVIEW

The **WIF India Screenwriters Lab** is a first-of-its-kind, genre-specific, Pan-India screenwriting initiative to identify and develop **6 strong feature film scripts** across Indian languages, mentored by some of the most powerful voices in contemporary Indian cinema.

The lab will support **mid-range fiction projects**, with a clear emphasis on **original voices, culturally rooted stories, and cinematic ambition**. WIF will not fund the films, but will offer **deep creative mentorship**, access to **pitching platforms**, and guidance towards grants and co-production networks.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS

- **Open to all Indian languages** – inclusive of regional storytellers
 - **Genre-focused Lab** – stronger market potential + creative rigour
 - **6 High-Profile Mentors** – one-on-one mentorship for each script
 - **Residential Lab in an artistic retreat location**
 - **Only Feature Film Scripts** eligible
 - **Festival tie-up** for global industry exposure
 - **Script & synopsis registration mandatory** with SWA or regional bodies
 - **Sponsorship & Pitching Support** from post-production/editing studios
 - **IP stays with the writer** – full ownership retained
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MENTORS (Proposed)

Each selected script will be mentored by one of the following icons:

- **Varun Grover** – *Masaan, Sacred Games*
- **Juhi Chaturvedi** – *Piku, October, Vicky Donor*
- **Smita Singh** – *Sacred Games, Scoop*
- **Payal Kapadia** – *All We Imagine as Light* (Cannes 2024 Grand Prix), *A Night of Knowing Nothing*
- **Kiran Rao** – *Laapataa Ladies, Dhobi Ghat*
- **Bhavani Iyer** – *Raazi, Black, Lootera*
- **Gauri Shinde** – *English Vinglish, Dear Zindagi*
- **Sumit Roy** – *Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani, Made in Heaven (Season 1)*
- **Seeta Menon** – *14 Phere, Kahaani 2, B.A. Pass*
- **Pooja Surti** – *Andhadhun, Monica, O My Darling, Merry Christmas*

TIMELINE

Phase	Details	Timeline
Call for Applications	Open nationwide across languages. Writers submit 2-page concept note (max 1200 words) with genre specified	October 2025
Shortlist	Top 50 entries selected by a pre-jury	December 2025
Treatment Phase	Shortlisted writers submit 5-page detailed treatments	Jan–Feb 2026
Final Selection	6 scripts selected, one per mentor	March 2026
Writers Lab Part 1	Residential 5-day workshop with mentors	May 2026
Writers Lab Part 2	Festival tie-in (e.g. TIFF India or Film Bazaar style) with 2–3 day industry showcase and pitching prep	August 2026

SUBMISSION GUIDELINES

- Open to Indian citizens
 - Must be original **fiction feature film** ideas only
 - Submit in **any Indian language** (include English translation if required)
 - **2-page pitch (1000–1200 words max)** for Round 1
 - Must specify **genre** clearly: drama, thriller, horror, comedy, sci-fi, etc.
 - Must be **registered with the Screenwriters Association (SWA)** or regional equivalents
 - No unregistered material will be accepted
 - **IP rights remain with the writer**
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SELECTION PROCESS

- Round 1: Shortlist of 50 based on concept, originality, voice
 - Round 2: 5-page treatment evaluated on story structure, character, market potential
 - Final 6 chosen in consultation with mentors
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POST-LAB SUPPORT

- Writers get **access to pitching sessions at festivals or partner studios**
 - Introductions to grant bodies and co-production markets (e.g. Hubert Bals, Aide aux Cinémas du Monde, NFDC Co-Production Market)
 - **Sponsorship benefits** from Final Draft and a post-production/editing studio (to be onboarded)
 - No direct funding, but **support for finding it**
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SPONSORSHIP STRATEGY

- **Final Draft:** Request software licenses, visibility as official sponsor, and in-kind prizes
- **Post-Production/Editing Studios:** Offer 1–2 days of offline/online edit space or DI trial for pitching materials (lookbook, proof-of-concept videos)
- Potential partners: **Prasad Labs, Prime Focus, Phantom FX, Red Chillies Post, or Bridge PostWorks**

PARTNER FESTIVAL TIE-UP

Take inspiration from Film Bazaar x TIFF model:

- **WIF India x Festival Lab Showcase**
 - Invite global programmers, buyers, sales agents
 - Opportunity to pitch with visuals or mood boards
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SCRIPT REGISTRATION

Mandatory with the following:

- **Screenwriters Association of India (SWA)**
 - For regional language scripts, explore:
 - **Malayalam Cine Technicians Association (MACTA)**
 - **South Indian Film Writers Association**
 - **Bengali Film Writers' Guild** (if active)
 - Any relevant local guild per language
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CREDITS & ATTRIBUTION

All films or projects that originate from the **WIF India Screenwriters Lab** must carry the following acknowledgment:

“Developed at the WIF India Screenwriters Lab”

This credit must appear in:

- **Opening credits** (if possible) or **end slate**
- All **pitch decks, lookbooks, and festival submissions**
- Any **public presentations** or **market screenings**

WIF India will **not claim IP** or **creative ownership**, but the credit must be included **irrespective of eventual producers or financiers**. This ensures visibility for the initiative, and recognition of WIF's role in mentoring and launching the project

ETHOS

This lab is designed to amplify voices that need to be heard, tell stories that matter, and bring underrepresented narratives into India's commercial and festival circuits. This is not just a lab, it's a movement to **give women and gender-marginalised writers a platform to be taken seriously by the industry.**